



Basic Biblical NUTRITION

Take 2... and Call Me in the Morning?

Answering your Functional Nutrition questions – Plain and Simple

Noni Fruit – Does Anyone Have a Clothes Pin?

Author: Tracey Williams CFNC - July 2026

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Noni Fruit... It's Personal

Noni Fruit, an odd topic to be discussing. However, it was brought up in a conversation I had with a dear friend a few weeks ago. I had heard of this fruit before, especially its nicknames like “**Cheese fruit**”, “**Vomit Fruit**” and “**Famine Food**”, but never knew why it was named as such or what, if any nutritional value it might have. So, here is what I found...

What is Noni Fruit?

Noni fruit or ‘*Morinda citrifolia*’ is a fruit-bearing tree native to southeast Asia, Pacific islands and Australia. It was spread and cultivated in the Pacific region by Polynesian sailors. Noni fruit is in the coffee family (*Rubiaceae*) with over 100 native nicknames such as:

Great Morinda, Indian Mulberry, Noni, Beach Mulberry, Painkiller Tree, Awl Tree, and Cheese fruit. It is also known by a few unsavory names including **Starvation Fruit, Famine Food** and get this... **Vomit**

Fruit!! Yikes!! I’m not sure I’d ever want to try a fruit called ‘Vomit Fruit’!! It certainly does not sound appetizing! Anyway, moving on. Due to its pungent odor, this lumpy, yellow green potato-sized fruit is sometimes called **Cheese fruit**. Once ripe, the fruit turns translucent white and is described as having a sharp or bitter taste. Though very rarely eaten raw, noni is usually ingested as a fermented juice, blended with other fruit juices, or mixed into a smoothy as a powdered supplement. For those brave adventurous souls (*and you know who you are*) unripe noni fruit can also be cooked in culinary cuisines like curries and stir-fry to mask its bitter flavour, or made into a spicy condiment. By the way, warnings in document reviews indicate to be aware that it is an acquired taste similar to bleu cheese, rotting cheese or vomit, hence the nickname **Vomit Fruit**. *Oh yum?? That name really gets those gastric juices flowing! Yeah right!*



Did you know? For over two thousand years, the Polynesians used all parts of the plant (fruit, leaves, stems, flowers and roots) to treat skin conditions, arthritis and infections. Some of the indigenous peoples considered the noni fruit an emergency food source during famines thus the name **Starvation Fruit**, [1] while the Pacific Islanders incorporated it into their diet as a staple food, eating the noni fruit raw or cooked.[2] In Thailand and Cambodia, the leaves are used as the main ingredient, with the noni tree leaves being an essential ingredient of one of the Cambodian national dishes *fish amok*. [3] **NOTE:** Fish amok is believed to have been a royal Khmer dish dating back to the Khmer Empire also known as the Angkor Period in Cambodian history dating from 802 to 1431 AD. [4]

The Functional Nutrition Approach:

Above we looked at some of the prevalent ‘nicknames’ for Noni Fruit, such as Cheese fruit, Vomit Fruit, Famine Food and Starvation Fruit, and a ‘story’ behind potentially how some of the nicknames were



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derived. Now let's look at one last nickname: **Painkiller Tree**. *Yeah... I was scratching my head as to how to address the Noni Plant from a Functional Nutrition perspective. So, here goes...*

As mentioned above, the Polynesians used the Noni plant to treat ailments such as, skin conditions, arthritis and infections... *Were they on to something? Let's take a look...* This tropical fruit is:

- Nutrient-dense and rich in anti-oxidants: The Noni fruit is rich in anti-oxidants like Vitamin A, C, and E. It contains powerful compounds that combat free radicals, reduce oxidative stress, and protect against cellular damage.
- It supports Immune Function: The Noni fruit contains high levels of Vitamin C and other antioxidants that help boost immune activity and protect against infections.
- It can reduce Inflammation: This tropical fruit aids in pain management, particularly for joint pain and arthritis.
- It may promote Heart Health: This fruit helps maintain healthy blood pressure levels, reduces cholesterol, and prevents the oxidation of LDL cholesterol.
- It supports Skin and Hair Health: The high vitamin content (specifically biotin and folate) in the noni fruit promotes skin health, increases collagen production, and helps with conditions like acne or eczema.
- It may help with Physical Endurance: Noni may improve energy levels, increase endurance, and reduce fatigue. [5]

Brent West et.al. in the 2018 PubMed Central article *"The Potential Health Benefits of Noni Juice: A Review of Human Intervention Studies"* describes Noni juice's antioxidant activity in human studies this way:

"It is this activity and its interaction with the immune system and inflammation pathways that may account for much of the observed health benefits of noni juice. These health benefits may include protection against tobacco smoke toxicities—including DNA protection, normalization of blood lipids, control of systemic inflammation, and reduction of homocysteine—improvement of joint pain and mobility, increased physical endurance, increased immune activity, control of AGE [advanced glycation end-products] accumulation, weight management, maintenance of bone health in women, control of blood pressure, and improved gum health." [5]

Noni roots, stem, bark, leaves, flowers, and fruit have all been used for 'medicinal' purposes. Noni is rich in Vitamin C and contains significant amounts of Vitamin E and the B vitamins, particularly folate and biotin. Minerals include iron, calcium, potassium, magnesium, copper, zinc, phosphorus, and selenium. [6]

Proceed to Use with Caution?

With what looks like wonderful health benefits with noni fruit, one must also consider the side effects of ingesting noni. There isn't enough reliable evidence to indicate noni juice's safety. However, here are some **Safety & Precautions to consider**:

- **Kidney Concerns**: Noni juice is naturally high in potassium, so people with kidney disease should exercise caution or avoid consumption. [7]
- **Liver Concerns**: Liver damage and hepatitis have been linked with high or regular noni consumption, so individuals with liver conditions should avoid it. [7]
- **High potassium levels (Hyperkalemia)**: Drinking noni juice may increase potassium levels well over healthy levels in those who already have too much potassium in the blood. [7]



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- **Pregnancy and breast-feeding:** RxList states, “Historically, noni has been used to cause abortions.” *Yikes!! If pregnant or trying to get pregnant, it is best to avoid noni juice like the plague!* As for breast feeding, there just not enough known about the safety of taking noni while nursing. Again, ‘best to play it safe’ and avoid noni fruit while breast feeding. [7]
- **Drug Interactions:** Noni may interact with blood thinners (like Warafarin), some blood pressure medications (such as, ACE inhibitors, Angiotensin receptor blockers (ARBs), and Antihypertensive drugs), water pills (potassium-sparing diuretics), Rantidine (formerly known as Zantac) and anti-epileptic drugs. [7]

Due to the high levels of potassium in the noni, side effects may include liver and kidney issues like those already mentioned, irregular heartbeat, muscle weakness, gastrointestinal problems like abdominal pain, nausea or diarrhea, and rare allergic reactions. **It is crucial that before ingesting noni fruit to consult a doctor and adhere to their instructions,** particularly for those with kidney or liver disease, pregnant/nursing, and/or on certain medications. According to a WebMD article, Noni fruit is generally considered safe for healthy adults when consumed in moderation via mouth for up to 3 months, with doses of 3-4 ounces of juice once or twice daily being tolerable. Non-pasteurized, fermented noni juice is commonly consumed, with some reports suggesting starting with smaller amounts to assess tolerance, potentially increasing to several ounces daily. However, there are several reports of liver damage in people who consumed noni tea or juice for several weeks. Unfortunately, “it isn't clear if noni was the cause of these side effects. There isn't enough reliable information to know if noni fruit extract is safe.” [6]

Concluding Remarks

The noni fruit is nutrient and anti-oxidant packed with vitamins C and A and very high in potassium that has the potential to repair damaged cells in the body and boost immune system activity. Noni in its various ‘medicinal’ forms has been used for a wide range of conditions including some forms of cancer, skin conditions including anti-aging, digestive and immune system support, diabetes, cataracts, and athletic performance, as well as other conditions.

However, noni is not FDA approved and there is very little research or good scientific evidence to support its safety. According to RxList, “Noni is POSSIBLY SAFE when taken by mouth or when an ointment containing noni is applied to the skin. However, there are several reports of liver damage in people who consumed noni tea or juice for several weeks. It is not known for certain if noni was the cause of these side effects.” [7]

So where does that leave us? Good question... Considering there isn't enough evidence to the effectiveness and safety of noni fruit... So, **do proceed with caution and trepidation** if you plan to use it as a supplement. And by all means and I re-iterate... by all means... **It is crucial that before ingesting noni fruit to consult a doctor and adhere to their instructions,** particularly if you have kidney or liver disease, pregnant/nursing, and/or on certain medications. I recommend in the place of noni fruit, consider eating healthy meals consisting of ‘healthy fat’, fiber and protein and incorporating the Food Rainbow.

Some Where Over the Rainbow:

The **Food Rainbow** that is! We can find many of the nutrients found in the noni fruit, such as, Potassium, anti-oxidants (Vitamin C, Vitamin A, and Vitamin E), Vitamin B (Biotin and Folate), Iron, Calcium, Magnesium, Copper, Zinc. Phosphorus and Selenium in the **“Foods of the Rainbow”**. Combining the **Food Rainbow** with consistently eating ‘healthy fat’, fiber and protein at each meals and



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in snacks, we will receive the beneficial nutrients without the uncertainties surrounding ingesting the noni fruit.

When we “**Eat the Rainbow**”, we safely get a wide variety of colorful fresh fruits and vegetables daily to ensure a broad intake of the essential nutrients, antioxidants, and phytochemicals that our bodies need. (NOTE: The latest USDA “*Dietary Guidelines for Americans*” recommends 3 servings of vegetables and 2 servings of fruit per day.) [8] For example, the green fruits and vegetables such as kale, spinach, broccoli and avocado are teaming with vitamins (such as folate), minerals, lutein, chlorophyll, and cancer-fighting anti-oxidants which are detoxifying and support brain, heart, mitochondria function, and the immune system. The reds, such as tomatoes, apples, raspberries, and goji berries are high in lycopene and anthocyanins which support heart health and reduce cancer risk. The orange and yellow fruits and vegetables are packed the carotenoids boosting skin, eye and immune health. [9] *Sounds like we are covering a lot of the healthy bases!* 😊

The phytonutrients found in the plants of the **Food Rainbow** are natural compounds that give them their, brilliant colour, flavour and healthful benefits... *And guess what? No stinky odors to disrupt our digestive juices from flowing! Yeah! I can go for that!!* With this in mind, let’s safely eat a variety of nutrient-dense fruits and vegetables with each meal and avoid wearing a clothes pin over our noses while eating. *hehehe* So, **On Your Mark! Get Set! Go! Go “Eat the Rainbow”!** Go eat those vitamins and minerals your body needs and **Enjoy a Healthier You** without the ‘Vomit Fruit’ after-taste!

And remember...

“Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God.” 1 Cor 10:31 (KJV)

Reference material available upon request.

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Tracey Williams is not a medical doctor. She is a Certified Functional Nutrition Counselor/Researcher. Tracey Williams does not diagnose or treat any medical illness or condition.



Tracey Williams, CFNC
At **Basic Biblical Nutrition**, we believe that **it IS personal** — because everything is connected, every person is uniquely created, and all things matter. We approach Functional Nutrition through a biblical lens, continually asking, “What does God say?” as we pursue health that glorifies Him in body, mind, and spirit. As Scripture reminds us:
“Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God.”
(1 Cor 10:31, KJV)

Nourishing Body. Mind. Spirit.

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